network, equipped with spyware, CCTV cameras, facial recognition and voice recognition software, and vast searchable databases. If a government wishes, its surveillance network can reach everywhere, from markets to places of worship, from schools to private residences. (And while not every government is willing or able to install cameras inside people's homes, algorithms regularly watch us even in our living rooms, bedrooms, and bathrooms via our own computers and smartphones.)

Governmental surveillance networks also routinely collect biometric data from entire populations, with or without their knowledge. For example, when applying for a passport, more than 140 countries oblige their citizens to provide fingerprints, facial scans or iris scans.[24] When we use our passports to enter a foreign country, that country often demands that we provide it, too, with our fingerprints, facial scans or iris scans.[25] As citizens or tourists walk along the streets of Delhi, Beijing, Seoul or London, their movements are likely to be recorded. For these cities – and many others around the world – are covered by more than one hundred surveillance cameras on average per square kilometre. Altogether, in 2023 more than one billion CCTV cameras were operative globally, which is about one camera per eight people.[26]

Any physical activity a person engages in leaves a data trace. Every purchase made is recorded in some database. Online activities like messaging friends, sharing photos, paying bills, reading news, booking appointments or ordering taxis can all be recorded as well. The resulting ocean of data can then be analyzed by AI systems to identify unlawful activities, suspicious patterns, missing persons, disease carriers or political dissidents.

As with every powerful technology, these systems can be used for either good or bad purposes. Following the storming of the US Capitol on 6 January 2021, the FBI and other US law enforcement agencies used state-of-the-art surveillance systems to track down and arrest the rioters. As reported in a *Washington Post* investigation, these agencies relied not only on footage from the CCTV cameras in the Capitol, but also on social media posts, licence plate readers throughout the country, cell-tower location records and pre-existing databases.

One Ohio man wrote on Facebook that he had been in Washington that day to 'witness history'. A subpoena was issued to Facebook, which provided the FBI with the man's Facebook posts, as well as his credit card